

In this paper, I propose an intellectual regimen that will practice intellectual humility through exercising one's ability to gauge the appropriate level of confidence in one's beliefs. This regimen is tailored towards people who are easily swayed by external voices, thus leading to excessive humility and lack of justified confidence in beliefs that are epistemically sound, as this is something I struggle with, but can also be adapted to help reduce overconfidence. This regimen is not intended to simply boost confidence levels in the person's beliefs; however, it is meant to help the person feel confident in the degree of doxastic openness they should hold regarding their belief, rather than be overly open at all times.

My regimen is a "Confidence Tracker", and is conducted as follows:

1. At the beginning of each month, choose a topic of discussion on a controversial topic (i.e. one that two intelligent, informed people can dispute) that you have recently been informed about, through class, the news, or from a conversation. The key is for this to be a relevant topic that is being discussed a lot.
2. Write down your current belief on the topic. If you have no beliefs, look into the information you have obtained to see if you should have an opinion. Then, rank your confidence level in the reasonableness of this opinion, as well as your doxastic openness (i.e. how confident you think you should be in the degree of confidence you have).
3. Throughout the month, track the discussions and new information you have learned with regards to this topic. At the end of each week, rewrite and rank your belief again. At the end of the month, observe how your opinion and confidence levels have changed: Did your belief oscillate considerably over the one month period? Did your confidence level oscillate greatly over the one month period? This second question serves as a measure of whether your initial gauge of doxastic openness was accurate to the actual variation in your confidence levels.

As time progresses, the goal is that my predicted doxastic openness will become closer to the actual fluctuation in my confidence levels. This will hopefully then translate into the discussions that I have with people as well; I will no longer be as easily swayed, since I have a sense of how grounded my opinion is, and therefore I will be able to assess counterarguments with varying degrees of seriousness.

Before entering analysis of this method, we first start with establishing what is an intellectual virtue. Baehr highlights four main dimensions of an intellectual virtue:

motivational, affective, competence, and judgment. By motivational, he means that these virtues originate from a love for the epistemic goods, motivated by the prospect of gaining more knowledge, not of gaining social status or other aims. In addition, observers find intellectual virtues attractive and hope to emulate them. Baehr also says that these virtues are affective in the sense that the intellectually virtuous find learning to be enjoyable not burdensome. Thirdly, there is a competence dimension – occasionally exercising these virtues is not enough – one must be sufficiently competent at exercising them; inconsistent demonstration of intellectually virtuous acts does not constitute intellectual virtuosity. Finally, there is a judgment component which helps the person determine which virtues should be deployed in which situations. Baehr terms this to be *phronesis*, or practical wisdom. The question of whether or not the intellectual virtue must yield reliable beliefs, and where the role of epistemic luck comes into play is also addressed as a result of these four tenets. Baehr comes to a “conditional reliability” requirement, which claims that due to the competency dimension, the individual will be epistemically reliable given that they are in a favorable environment (i.e. there is no external barrier to the formation of true beliefs) – this then allows for exceptions where an individual is epistemically virtuous yet unable to form reliable beliefs simply because they have bad epistemic luck and their environment does not allow them to.

Using this framework to describe an intellectual virtue, we now turn to exploring why intellectual humility is a virtue. Intellectual humility is the quality of acknowledging one’s limits in knowledge and understanding and therefore being open to change one’s mind when presented with new information. The motivational aspect is evident from a genuinely motivated seeker of knowledge being open to acknowledging that their belief is wrong, and observers finding this judicious open-mindedness to be admirable. Similarly, someone who is intellectually virtuous would be excited by the idea that the path towards greater knowledge is never ending and beliefs that are held are not set in stone. Third, competence in intellectual humility will indeed lead to the formation of more reliable beliefs under good epistemic circumstances, and fourth, the application of intellectual humility requires judgment – one must find a balance between being overconfident in one’s beliefs versus being too humble and thus swayed by weak arguments as well as strong ones. My proposed regimen specifically targets competence and judgment, as it trains judgment on the appropriate amount of intellectual humility, and without competence, the judgment is essentially ineffective. Ballantyne offers a method through which we could train our judgment to know our limits and discover whether our controversial beliefs are epistemically reasonable.

Ballantyne suggests that we should hold different degrees of confidence in our beliefs, specifically controversial beliefs that spawn disagreement even between two reasonable, intelligent people. Ballantyne argues that the key to distinguishing the appropriate level of confidence is identifying the defeaters to one's belief. Defeaters are essentially any reason that could potentially undermine the "positive epistemic status" of the belief. While positive epistemic status is defined differently by internalists versus externalists who debate the necessary epistemic access to reasons for a belief to have positive status, it is agreed upon that an undefeated defeater negates the positive status of a belief. According to Ballantyne, there are different types of defeaters – partial and full defeaters. Whether a reason is a partial or full defeater depends on the context; for example, if one already has encountered many defeaters to one's beliefs, then the most recent undefeated defeater may become a full defeater, which makes the belief unreasonable. On the other hand, partial defeaters may simply reduce the confidence with which the belief is held. The purpose of all of this is to ultimately determine the amount of doxastic openness one should hold regarding the confidence in one's beliefs. For example, if one knows that they should hold a belief with very little confidence because they have encountered multiple defeaters then one should be doxastically closed about knowing that the belief is not very reasonable.

My method uses Ballantyne's conception of measuring doxastic openness through evaluating defeaters. By writing down discussion and weighing counterarguments surrounding the chosen topic, you are evaluating the potential defeaters to your opinion. Then, by ranking your confidence level, you are keeping track of variation in confidence levels, so by the end of the month, you can compare how closely your confidence level variation matched the level of doxastic openness that you believed you had at the beginning of the month. Ideally, you are training your ability to evaluate defeaters rather than being confused by them, so that you can better gauge when it is appropriate to change confidence in your beliefs. Ultimately, knowing the amount of confidence you should hold in your belief is a key factor in cultivating intellectual humility, because it will ensure that you have the right amount of humility regarding your beliefs.

The reflection aspect of my regimen is particularly important, because without it, one may be absorbing information but not putting it to any practical purpose. This is emphasized by Kidd's analysis of Confucianism and self-cultivation. According to Kidd, Confucius states that "a person who genuinely loves learning aims not to acquire

knowledge for its own sake, but rather to employ it to improve their character.” Thus, one cannot simply go into discussion just aiming to learn more information, but also must have a goal in mind of how they intend to use this information. In the case of my regimen, the information gathered is then applied in a way to cultivate humility and improve one’s epistemic reasoning abilities. It is particularly fighting against the Confucian “disdain for people who fail to put into practice what they learn or who settle for the satisfaction of a facile curiosity about the world.” According to Kidd, the love of learning, which is so crucial in Confucianism, describes both the accumulation of knowledge as well as their application – my method attempts to foster a love of learning via the path of training intellectual humility.

We have thus explained that this method puts into practice Ballantyne’s suggested practice of knowing one’s epistemic limits in order to establish a balanced sense of intellectual humility, and through this process, a love of learning is being cultivated through the encouragement of acquiring and applying relevant knowledge to the betterment of oneself. However, some potential concerns people may have about this plan are:

1. Consistency and motivation
2. Practical Effects
3. Overconfidence

First, this is a relatively mentally taxing exercise and requires active engagement on the part of the user – the user has to be actively having discussion and seeking news about the topic in order to obtain new knowledge. Especially for someone who is not used to engaging with controversial topics, this could be quite a challenge. However, hopefully the person started this regimen aiming to become a more intellectually virtuous person and therefore will be motivated to continue even when it gets hard, just like any kind of physical exercise regimen.

Another problem may be that there are no particularly concrete effects of this exercise regimen, since most of it cultivates internal awareness. Thus, while it may manifest in changes like reduced indecisiveness and increased certainty of convictions, it doesn’t directly translate into actionable impact. Ideally though, once these psychological changes become habits, the user will begin to see in conversations that they have become an independently thoughtful person who is able to present their own opinions

while still listening to and considering the opposing side, rather than getting lost in the arguments of another.

A third concern may be that this method will push a person to go too far in the opposite direction and become overconfident in their opinions. I think my method accounts for this through the constant re-evaluation of confidence levels in addition to the re-evaluation of opinion. This makes sure that the person is constantly thinking about the appropriate level of confidence, which will hopefully mitigate any overconfidence; in fact, this method could actually address overconfidence – for example, if the person discovers that after a month, their belief has oscillated a lot despite having written down initial confidence in it, they might learn to take a more humble approach towards beliefs that they take for granted.

This method will likely start taking effect even after a couple of months, though it is best to stay with it long-term, especially because it does not take too much time to track your progress weekly and ideally you would be choosing a topic that is naturally coming up in many conversations anyway. In the worst-case scenario, someone could become demotivated by the lack of progress in measuring doxastic openness and give up. However, in the best-case scenario, that person would slowly understand what factors influence the confidence levels in their opinions and develop enough discernment to know when they are justified in holding fast to one belief over another. The final effect would be a balanced dose of intellectual humility and a love of learning that characterize an intellectually virtuous person.